Year 12 Admission Assessment v3.1: assessor instructions

Version 3.1, October 2026. Use with `Y12/Y12_Student_Paper_v3.1`. Year 12 joins the pack at version 3.1, so that every year group carries one version number: there is no earlier Year 12 paper. The core paper has the Years 7 to 10 structure (listening Parts A and B, reading Parts A and B, writing, maths in three sections, science) at the level of a student finishing IGCSE and starting A Level. Two further parts are given from their own booklets: the **cognitive ability screen** (`shared/Cognitive_Ability_Screen_Y11_Y12`, with its guide `shared/Cognitive_Ability_Screen_Guide`) and the **optional sciences** (`Y12/Y12_Optional_Sciences_v3.1`, with `Y12/Y12_Optional_Sciences_Mark_Scheme_v3.1`). Do not mix papers and instructions from different years or versions: the question numbers, marks and band guides differ.

Reusable: print once and keep in the assessor's folder. Do not write on these pages. Record each candidate's marks on their own **grading sheet** (`Y12_Grading_Sheet_v3.1`), reading on the **Reading front sheet** and the interview on the **Interview sheet**.

- **Listening** (16 marks): Part A is an everyday phone conversation (a school student and her cousin at university); **Part B** is a talk at the level of a lesson (turning seawater into drinking water).
- **Reading** (16 marks): Part A is a web page for a summer academy; Part B is an opinion article, "Lost, and Better for It" (questions 8 to 14), in the style of an IGCSE First Language English text.
- **Writing** (16 marks): a story, or an essay that must answer a counter-argument.
- **Maths** (30 marks): three sections that are scored separately: **Fluency** (10), **Word questions** (8) and **Applied problems** (12). A scientific calculator is allowed in Section C only.
- **Science** (10 marks): end-of-IGCSE level across biology, chemistry and physics, with one working-scientifically question.
- **Cognitive ability screen** and **optional sciences**: separate booklets, recorded on this year's grading sheet (Section 7).

Who this is for. Students applying for **Year 12** (age 16 on 1 September), the first year of the school's **A Level** course. A student from a Chinese mainstream school has usually **completed Grade 10 (高一)**: senior-high maths year 1 (sets, functions including exponential and logarithmic functions, trigonometric functions, vectors in two dimensions), physics (motion, forces, Newton's laws, energy), chemistry (the mole and amount of substance, redox, the periodic table) and biology (cells and molecules). They have usually **not** sat IGCSE. Some come from an international or bilingual school that teaches IGCSE: ask which syllabuses and which papers (Core or Extended) they have followed. A student joining mid-year is partway through Grade 11 (高二). Ask the student and the family which grade and which textbooks they have used, because the order of topics differs between textbooks and regions. Background on Chinese school sequences, the English bands and the decision guide is in `00_Admissions_Guide.md`.

What it measures. The student's level of English in listening, reading, writing and speaking (bands A to E) against the English that A Level study needs; their maths against the end of IGCSE Extended and the start of A Level Maths, reported as three sub-scores (fluency, word questions and applied problems); their core science against the end of IGCSE; the optional sciences against the subjects they want to take at A Level; and, through the cognitive ability screen, a profile for planning support (never for selection). Section 6 explains how to read the results together to judge **readiness for A Level study in English**.

1. At a glance

Order	Task	Minutes	Who leads	Materials	Print
1	Welcome	2	Assessor		These instructions
2	Listening: Part A (questions 1 to 8) and Part B (questions 9 to 16), 16 marks	about 17 (the recording)	Assessor plays the recording, or reads both scripts (Section 3.1); a small group is fine	Student paper pages 2 to 5; pencil; the recording	Student paper; grading sheet
3	Reading paper: Parts A and B (16 marks)	15	Student works alone	Student paper pages 6 to 10	

Order	Task	Minutes	Who leads	Materials	Print
4	Writing: one task from two (16 marks)	10	Student works alone	Student paper pages 11 to 12	
5	Break	5		Water	
6	Maths: Section A Fluency, Section B Word questions, Section C Applied problems (30 marks)	25	Student works alone; the assessor may read any question aloud	Student paper pages 13 to 19; pencil, rubber, ruler; **no calculator in Sections A and B**; a **scientific calculator for Section C only** (from page 17); no protractor	A scientific calculator for each student
7	Core science: 7 questions (10 marks)	8	Student works alone; the assessor may read any question aloud	Student paper pages 20 to 22; no calculator	
8	Break	5		Water	
9	Cognitive ability screen: non-verbal 12, quantitative 12, verbal 12, processing speed (90 seconds, out of 60); strictly timed	25	Assessor gives it from the guide; a small group is fine	The screen booklet (one per student); pencil; a stopwatch; no calculator	Screen booklet; its guide (once)
10	Optional sciences: Biology, Chemistry, Physics (15 marks each); only the sciences the student will take; a short break after two	15 each	Student works alone; the assessor may read any question aloud	The optional sciences paper; scientific calculator allowed	Optional sciences paper; its mark scheme (once)
11	Interview, opening with the Graded Sentence Reading Screen at **Level 9**	15	Interviewer, 1:1	Sentence Reading Card (laminated); a plain card to cover sentences	Reading front sheet; Interview sheet (Years 11 and 12)
	Total	**about 122** (core; allow 125)		A clock or timer	Final mark sheet

A long day. The core (tasks 1 to 9) takes about two hours (allow 125 minutes); with two optional sciences the day is about 2 hours 35 minutes, and with three about 2 hours 50 minutes. The booklet names are in the list below. If the student is taking two or three optional sciences, the optional sciences and the interview **may be given on a second visit**: say so to the family when the date is booked, and record on the grading sheet which parts were taken on which day. The parent conversation runs alongside.

Marks go on the **grading sheet** (listening, writing, maths, science, the optional sciences, the cognitive screen and readiness for A Level), the **Reading front sheet** (reading) and the **Interview sheet** (speaking).

For each candidate:

- the Year 12 student paper, version 3.1;
- the cognitive ability screen booklet (`shared/Cognitive_Ability_Screen_Y11_Y12`);
- the optional sciences paper (`Y12/Y12_Optional_Sciences_v3.1`), if any science is taken;
- the grading sheet (`Y12/Y12_Grading_Sheet_v3.1`);
- the Reading front sheet (`forms/Reading_Front_Sheet`);
- the Interview sheet for Years 11 and 12 (`forms/Interview_Sheet_Y11_Y12`);
- the parent conversation record (`forms/Parent_Conversation_Record`);
- the final mark sheet (`forms/Candidate_Summary_and_Decision`).

For the room (print once, laminate the cards):

- these instructions;
- the cognitive ability screen guide (`shared/Cognitive_Ability_Screen_Guide`);

- the optional sciences mark scheme (`Y12/Y12_Optional_Sciences_Mark_Scheme_v3.1`);
- the Interviewer guide (`forms/Interviewer_Guide_Y11_Y12`);
- `shared/Sentence_Reading_Guide`;
- the sentence reading card (`shared/Sentence_Reading_Card`; laminate it);
- the other equipment in the table above: a clock or timer, a stopwatch for the cognitive screen, a plain card to cover the sentences, and a scientific calculator for each student (with a pencil, rubber and ruler for each candidate).

The parent conversation (`forms/Parent_Conversation_Record`, about 15 minutes) can run at the same time with another member of staff. The written papers (tasks 2 to 10) can be taken in a small group with one invigilator; the interview is always 1:1.

2. Before you start

Room. Quiet, bright, a clock the student can see, the student paper face down, a pencil, rubber and ruler. Keep a scientific calculator for each student on your desk until they reach maths Section C. Keep the cognitive screen booklet and the optional sciences paper out of sight until their turn. Glasses or hearing aids if the student uses them.

Say (welcome): "Hello, I am [name]. Thank you for coming today. These activities help us get to know you, so that we can help you when you join us. Some questions are easy and some are hard. Nobody gets everything right, and that is fine. Do your best. If you do not know an answer, go on to the next question. Please write all your answers in English. In the English parts, I can only repeat the instructions. In maths and science, I can read any question to you. You can use a calculator only in the last section of the maths, and I will give it to you then. After this paper and a break, there are some shorter booklets. Do you have any questions before we start?"

Pace of speech. Year 12 students may still be learning English: speak steadily and clearly, with a short pause after each sentence, when you give instructions, read the listening scripts and read maths and science questions aloud. Use the same pace for every candidate, so that the results can be compared. The listening recording is paced the same way. Do not slow down for an older student who seems fluent: the pace is part of the measure.

Access rules (the same in every year group, with the calculator rule for Years 9 to 12)

	English sections (listening, reading, writing, sentence reading)	Maths and science (core and optional); the cognitive screen
Reading aloud	Read only what the script says. Do not read the reading texts or questions aloud, explain words or translate. Instructions may be repeated in English.	Any question may be read aloud in English, as often as the student asks. You may point to the picture. In the cognitive screen, only the instructions and the worked examples may be read aloud or repeated, in English.
Chinese	Not used by staff.	If a Chinese-speaking colleague is present and the student clearly cannot follow the English after it has been read aloud, the colleague may say the question **once** in Chinese. Write **L** in the margin. The mark still counts. Record the number of L questions on the grading sheet: it is evidence about English. No Chinese in the cognitive screen.
Answers	**All answers in English.** An answer in Chinese scores 0.	**All answers in English**: numbers, symbols, words, ticks, drawings and working all count. An answer or explanation in Chinese scores 0 (this includes the "Explain" and "Show" answers in maths Section C and in science).
Calculator	Not used.	Maths Sections A and B: **no calculator**. Maths Section C: a **scientific calculator**. Core science: no calculator. Optional sciences: a scientific calculator. Cognitive screen: no calculator.
Not yet taught		If the student says they have not learnt a topic, write **NT** beside the question. It scores 0. List NT topics on the grading sheet.

Extra time, a reader or other arrangements for a known need are allowed: record them on the grading sheet. The cognitive screen is strictly timed; if extra time is given there, record it, because the scores are then not comparable.

Stopping rules

- The student may stop any section when they have done what they can. Say: "That is fine. Thank you. We will go on to the next part."
- **Listening:** if the student scores 2 or fewer out of 8 in Part A (questions 1 to 8), you may leave out Part B: check Part A quickly in the minute after it. Say: "Thank you. That is the end of the listening." Record "Part B not given" on the grading sheet; the band then comes from Part A alone (band A). In a group, play Part B to everyone as usual; a student with 2 or fewer in Part A may sit quietly.
- **Reading paper:** if the student cannot answer any of Part A after about 4 minutes, let them stop and record it on the Reading front sheet. Do not move them on to Part B.
- **Writing:** if the student has written nothing in English after 3 minutes, say once: "Write anything you can in English: a few words or sentences about yourself is fine." Then let them stop when they wish.
- **Maths and science:** encourage the student to look at every page, because later questions on different topics may be easier for them. Do not stop early unless the student is distressed. Give the calculator when the student turns to Section C (page 17); in a group, give each student theirs when they reach that page. If a student goes back to Section A or B after that, take the calculator back while they work on it.
- **Cognitive screen and optional sciences:** follow their own guides. A student whose English band from the morning is A or B still takes the cognitive screen: it is the part least dependent on English, and it is where such a student can show their reasoning.
- If a student becomes upset at any point, stop, take a break, and continue only if they are happy to. Record it on the grading sheet.

Keeping the student at ease. Smile, use the student's name, and keep your voice calm. Do not say "right" or "wrong" during the tasks; say "thank you" instead. Give a two-minute warning before the end of the reading paper, maths and science. A student who finishes early may check their work quietly.

3. English

3.1 Listening (16 marks: Part A 8, Part B 8)

There are two parts, and each is played or read twice. **Part A** is everyday listening: a phone conversation between a school student and her cousin, a university student. **Part B** is a short lesson-style talk with subject vocabulary, statistics, a correction and an implied opinion: the listening that A Level lessons need, at the level of a fluent speaker of 16 to 17.

Recording. A recording of this test is in `audio/v3.1/Y12/` (see its `READ_ME_FIRST.txt` for the tracks and timings). Play it instead of reading the script: every candidate then hears the same voices, pace and pauses. The script below is its transcript, and the live reading option if no recording can be played. Read live at the recording's pace: one reading of Part A takes about 2 minutes 24 seconds and of Part B about 3 minutes 27 seconds, with the pauses; use this to check your own pace. Do not pause the recording during a reading of the script. Play Part A and Part B as separate tracks if you may stop after Part A; otherwise the full track plays both.

Part A. Say: "Turn to the Listening page. There are two parts. In Part A, you will hear a phone conversation between Li Na, a school student, and her cousin Chen Yu, who is at university. I will play it two times. First, you have one minute to read questions 1 to 8." Wait one minute. **Say:** "Now listen." Play or read the Part A script. Wait 10 seconds. **Say:** "Now listen again." Play or read it again. Then give the student one more minute to finish.

Part B. Say: "Now turn to Part B, on page 4. You will hear a talk by an engineer, Dr Wang Hao, about turning seawater into drinking water. I will play it two times. First, you have one minute to read questions 9 to 16." Wait one minute. **Say:** "Now listen." Play or read the Part B script. Wait 10 seconds. **Say:** "Now listen again." Play or read it again. Then give the student one more minute to finish.

Read both scripts twice at the steady pace in Section 2. In Part A, say each speaker's name before their line, a little more quietly, both times. In Part B, read as a teacher gives a short lesson, without slowing down for the numbers or the subject words. At each [pause], stop for about 3 seconds. Do not repeat lines or explain anything.

Timing. The recording takes about 17 minutes: Part A about 7 minutes 42 seconds and Part B about 9 minutes 41 seconds, with one minute to read each set of questions, the 10-second gaps between the two readings and one

minute to finish each part. **Allow about 17 minutes** for the listening.

Script, Part A: a phone call to a cousin at university

Li Na: Hi, Chen Yu! Thanks for calling back. How is university?

Chen Yu: Busy, but I love it. I'm in my second year of architecture now, in Nanjing.

Li Na: Architecture? I thought you were going to study medicine, like your mum.

Chen Yu: Everyone thought so! But I always liked drawing buildings more than reading about the human body. [pause]

Li Na: Where do you live? In a flat?

Chen Yu: No, in a student hall on the campus. In my first year, I shared a room with five other students. This year there are only four of us in the room, so it's much quieter. [pause]

Li Na: How do you get to your classes?

Chen Yu: I cycle. The bus is free for students, but it stops everywhere, so it takes twice as long. By bike, it's ten minutes. [pause]

Li Na: What time do your classes start?

Chen Yu: On Mondays, my first lecture is at eight o'clock. On the other days, it's nine. Your school starts at half past seven, doesn't it? So you'd find it easy. [pause]

Li Na: Do you have a job?

Chen Yu: Yes, I work in a café near the library on Wednesday afternoons. In the first month, I got twenty yuan an hour. Now I get twenty-five. [pause]

Chen Yu: Some weeks are hard, though. Before my last project was due, I drew for fourteen hours in one day.

Li Na: Fourteen hours! I don't think I could do that.

Chen Yu: You'd be surprised. When you're building something you care about, you forget the time. [pause]

Li Na: I have to choose my subjects for next year soon. Any advice?

Chen Yu: Yes. Three of my school friends chose physics because the rest of us did, and two of them changed courses after one term. Choose the subjects you actually want to get up at eight o'clock for. [pause]

Li Na: That's good advice. Thanks, Chen Yu.

Chen Yu: Any time. Come and visit, and I'll show you the model I'm building. [pause]

Part A answers (1 mark each). Spelling does not matter in listening if the meaning is clear (for example "studen hall"). This applies to Part B too.

Q	Answer	Also accept	Do not accept, and what it tells you
1	**B** (the building drawing: architecture)		A (medicine: what everyone expected her to study)
2	**in a student hall**		"in a flat" (Li Na's guess, which Chen Yu corrects)
3	**B** (the café)		
4	**4**	four	6 or 5 (the first year: "five other students"); 3 (the others, not counting Chen Yu)
5	**10** (minutes)	ten	20 (twice as long: the bus)
6	**25** (yuan)	twenty-five; ¥25	20 (the first month: the question says "now")

Q	Answer	Also accept	Do not accept, and what it tells you
7	**She could not work (draw) for fourteen hours in one day**	It is too long; she would be too tired; she could not concentrate that long; she thinks it is too hard	"She cannot draw"; "she does not like architecture"; an answer about the café
8	**To warn her not to choose a subject because her friends choose it**	To show what happens when you follow your friends (two of them changed course); to persuade her to choose what she really wants	"Because they study physics"; "because they are her friends"; an answer that only repeats "two of them changed courses" with no reason

Script, Part B: a talk about turning seawater into drinking water

Good afternoon. My name is Dr Wang Hao, and I'm an engineer. I design plants that turn seawater into drinking water. [pause]

Only about two and a half per cent of the water on Earth is fresh, and most of that is frozen in ice caps and glaciers. Everything else is salty. A litre of seawater contains about thirty-five grams of salt: roughly six teaspoons. Drinking water should contain almost none. So the challenge is to remove nearly all the salt, cheaply, from an enormous amount of water. [pause]

There are two main ways. The oldest is distillation: you boil the seawater, the steam leaves the salt behind, and you cool the steam back into pure water. It works, but boiling water needs a great deal of energy. Most modern plants use a different method, called reverse osmosis. Osmosis is the natural movement of water through a very thin skin, or membrane, from the weaker solution to the stronger one. Reverse osmosis forces it the other way: seawater is pushed against the membrane at very high pressure, pure water passes through, and the salt stays behind. [pause]

Let me walk you through the plant my team studied last year. First, seawater is pumped in through a pipe that lies on the sea floor, some way out from the beach. Second, the water passes through sand filters, which remove sand, seaweed and tiny living things that would block the membranes. Third comes the reverse osmosis itself. Finally, before the water goes to the city, a small amount of minerals is added back, because completely pure water tastes flat, and a little chlorine protects it in the pipes. [pause]

That plant produces one hundred thousand cubic metres of drinking water a day. Actually, let me correct that: it was a hundred thousand when it opened. Since the second stage was added, it produces one hundred and fifty thousand, which is enough for about half a million people. [pause]

Now the costs. For every two litres of seawater that enter, roughly one litre of drinking water comes out. The other litre, now twice as salty, is called brine, and it is returned to the sea. Brine is denser than seawater, so it sinks and spreads along the sea floor. Most sea creatures live near the shore, in shallow water, so the brine has to be released slowly and far out. The second cost is electricity. The pumps use a great deal of it, and at that plant the water costs about twice as much as river water. [pause]

Some people now say that a coastal city with a desalination plant never needs to worry about water again. I notice that the same city loses nearly a fifth of its water through leaking pipes before it reaches a single tap. I would rather fix the pipes first. [pause]

The sea is not going to run out. But turning it into a drink has a price, paid in energy and in the health of the coast. Whether a city should pay it is a question for all of us, not only for engineers. Thank you. [pause]

Part B answers (1 mark each). Spelling does not matter in listening if the word is recognisable and the meaning is clear. Every answer is said in the script, and the questions follow the order of the script.

Q	Skill	Answer	Also accept	Do not accept, and what it tells you
9	Specific detail (a number)	**35** (grams)	thirty-five; about 35	2.5 (the percentage of fresh water); 6 (the teaspoons).
10	Note completion (a process)	**block**	clog; stop; blocked; recognisable spellings (blok)	"pass through"; "filter"; "remove" (the sand filters do the removing: the gap needs what the tiny living things would do to the membranes).
11	Note completion (a detail)	**minerals**	some minerals; a small amount of minerals; mineral; recognisable spellings (minerals, minrals)	"chlorine" (added to protect the water, not for taste); "salt"; "water".
12	Process or sequence	membranes **3**, pump in **1**, minerals and chlorine **4**, remove sand **2**		All four correct for the mark. Pumping and sand filters swapped, or membranes before the filters, is the usual error: the student heard the stages but not "First … Second … Third … Finally".
13	Specific detail (a number), after a correction	**150 000** (cubic metres)	150,000; one hundred and fifty thousand; 150 thousand	**100 000**: the figure he corrects ("Actually, let me correct that"). 500 000 (the people). An answer of 100 000 shows the student caught the first number but not the correction.
14	Inference joining two parts of the talk	**Brine is saltier and denser than seawater, so it sinks and spreads along the sea floor; most sea creatures live near the shore in shallow water, so brine released there could harm them.**	Any answer that links the brine (salty, dense, sinks) to the sea creatures near the shore: "it is very salty and animals live near the shore"; "so that it does not hurt the sea life in shallow water"; "it spreads along the bottom where the creatures are"	"Because it is waste"; "because it is dense" or "because it is salty" with no link to the sea creatures; "so that it mixes" with nothing more. The question joins the description of brine with the sentence about where sea creatures live.
15	Speaker's attitude (implied)	**B**: he thinks cities should stop wasting water through leaking pipes first		A is the opposite of his view (he says the sea will not run out, but that is not his point); C exaggerates (he describes a cost, not a reason to stop); D is the opposite of his last sentence. He never says the people are wrong: the student must hear the implication in "I would rather fix the pipes first."
16	Main idea or speaker's purpose	**B**: to explain how seawater is made drinkable and to weigh the benefits against the costs		A exaggerates (he does not say plants should close); C is not his purpose (he "studied" the plant and describes its costs); D is one detail, not the purpose. The structure (the problem, the method, the stages, the costs, the question for all of us) carries the purpose.

What is in the Part B script (for the English team): about 510 words in 36 sentences (about 14 words a sentence on average); about 20% of the word forms are outside the 2000 most common English words (`wordfreq` list, names left out). It explains a process (reverse osmosis and the four stages of the plant); compares distillation with reverse osmosis, seawater with brine, and desalinated water with river water; gives statistics; explains subject vocabulary in context (osmosis, membrane, reverse osmosis, pre-treatment, brine, desalination); corrects a number ("Actually, let me correct that"); implies opinions without stating them (the people who say a city never needs to worry; the leaking pipes; who should decide); and uses discourse markers (first, second, third, finally, in other words, now, so, but).

Band guide

Result	Band
Part A 0 to 2	**A** New to English
Part A 3 to 4	**B** Early acquisition
Part A 5 to 6, or Part A 7 to 8 with Part B 0 to 2	**C** Developing competence
Part A 7 to 8 with Part B 3 to 5	**D** Competent
Part A 7 to 8 with Part B 6 to 8	**E** Fluent

If the two parts disagree in an unexpected way (for example Part A 5 or 6 with Part B 5 or more), use the interview to decide: the student may have lost easy marks in Part A through nerves or carelessness.

What to look for

- **Part A** checks everyday listening: questions 1 to 3 the main points, 4 to 6 exact details with distractors (five other students, twice as long, twenty yuan), and 7 and 8 implied meaning and the speaker's purpose.
- **Part B** is the step up. Questions 9 to 13 need exact detail from fast, connected speech, with distractors (2.5%, chlorine, the order of the stages, 100 000); questions 14 to 16 need the student to join ideas, hear an attitude that is never stated and see the purpose of the whole talk. A student who gets 9 to 13 but not 14 to 16 follows the content of a lesson but not yet its argument, which is the skill A Level lessons and essays depend on.
- **Part A secure, Part B 0 to 2**: everyday English is fine, but lessons taught only by talk will be hard to follow at first. Plan visual support, key vocabulary in writing and frequent checks for understanding.
- Compare with listening in the interview. If the two differ by more than one band, use the interview as a check.

3.2 Reading paper (15 minutes, 16 marks)

Say: "Turn to the Reading page. There are two parts, A and B. Part B is harder. Read the texts yourself. I cannot read them to you or explain words. Do as much as you can. It is fine if you do not finish. You have 15 minutes." Give a two-minute warning.

General rules. Answers can be in the student's own words or copied from the text, unless the question says "copy" or "in your own words". Ignore spelling and grammar unless the answer cannot be understood. Answers must be in English; an answer in Chinese scores 0.

Part A: summer academy web page (accessible; picture support)

Q	Answer	Marks	Also accept / notes
1	20 to 31 July	1	20 July to 31 July; 20.7 to 31.7. Do not accept 6 to 17 July (Session 1).
2	¥4 500	1	4500; 4 500 yuan
3	Engineering Design; Debating and Public Speaking	2	1 mark for each correct tick, minus 1 for each wrong tick (minimum 0).
4	¥9 600	1	9600 (7 200 + 2 400). Do not accept 7 200 (the fee alone) or 10 100 (the deposit added again: the deposit is part of the fee, not extra; accept 9 600 only).
5	A letter from a teacher	1	a teacher's letter; a letter from your teacher. Do not accept "the online form" or "a deposit".
6	Marine Biology	1	
7	300 words on why he wants to attend, by 30 April	1	Both parts needed: what (300 words, or "why he wants to attend") and the date (30 April). Do not accept 15 May (the deposit date).

Part B: "Lost, and Better for It" (an opinion article in the style of an IGCSE First Language English text: a personal anecdote, a concession, a study, a counter-argument answered, figurative language and a point of view to be inferred; about 760 words)

Q	Skill	Answer	Marks	Also accept / notes
8	Explanation in own words	She no longer knew which way to go; she could not remember how she had got there; she lost her confidence (courage).	1	At least two of the three ideas, in the student's own words ("she did not know the way, and she was scared" is enough). Copying "sense of direction", "memory of the route" or "nerve" without rewording scores 0: this is the own-words check.
9	Vocabulary in context	ridiculous	1	
10	Inference	She relies on her phone automatically; the habit is so strong that she looks at the phone before she thinks; she depends on it even when there are other ways to find the route.	1	Any answer about automatic dependence or habit. Do not accept "she likes her phone" or "she could not see the tower".
11	Inference with evidence	She is pleased, grateful or warm about it; it was a happy, valuable meeting. Evidence: "the best conversation I had all weekend", or the detail of what he did (walked her to the corner, the bakeries, wished her a good journey).	1	Both the feeling and a piece of evidence are needed for the mark. "She was embarrassed" scores 0.
12	Effect of a writer's language choice	The phone does everything it is asked, without complaint and without stopping, like a servant; but, as the sentence goes on to say, being served all the time makes us "incapable". It is effective because a servant sounds like a good thing, and the writer turns it into a warning (we become helpless or dependent).	1	Any answer that goes beyond "it helps us": the idea of doing everything for us so that we lose the ability ourselves, or the twist from helpful to harmful. "It means the phone is useful" alone scores 0.
13	Writer's viewpoint	B: they are useful, but we should sometimes find our own way	1	A ignores "I am not about to suggest that anyone delete them"; C and D are overstatements the writer does not make.
14	Summary in own words	Two of: (1) when the app guides us we notice and remember nothing about the place (the mental-map skill fades); (2) we never speak to anyone (we miss other people); (3) we miss discovering unexpected or "excellent wrong" places; (4) we become dependent or incapable.	2	1 mark for each distinct reason in the student's own words. Two versions of the same reason score 1. A reason copied word for word from the text scores 0 for that reason.

Band guide (version 3.1; use judgement when a result is uneven, and check against the sentence reading screen)

Result	Band
Part A 0 to 3	**A** New to English
Part A 4 or more, Part B 0 to 2	**B** Early acquisition
Part B 3 to 5	**C** Developing competence
Part B 6 to 8	**D** Competent, or **E** Fluent (see below)

D or E. Part B is a text of the kind an IGCSE First Language English paper uses, so it is at or a little above the age level of a Year 12 entrant. Give **E** only when Part B is 7 or 8 **and** the sentence reading screen (meaning checks and fluency) and the writing also point to E. Six out of 8 with copied answers in questions 8 and 14 is a secure D, not an E.

Record the reading paper marks (Part A, Part B), the band and the question where the student stopped at 15 minutes on the **Reading front sheet**, and give it to the interviewer.

What to look for

- **Part B** is the hardest text on this paper and the closest to what A Level reading demands: an argument built from an anecdote, a concession ("I can hear the objection"), evidence and a modest proposal. A Part B score of 7 or 8 with answers in the student's own words shows a reader who can follow an argument in English and say what a writer is doing.

- **Strong readers** reword rather than copy (8 and 14), give evidence for an inference (11), and can say what a comparison does rather than only what it means (12). Copying whole lines that are in the right place but do not answer the question is the commonest sign of a band C or D reader.
- **An English barrier** looks like: Part A secure, Part B patchy or copied lines. A student who reads aloud well (sentence reading) but scores low on Part B may be decoding without understanding: see the meaning checks on the Reading front sheet.
- **Speed.** Note where the student was when time ran out, on the Reading front sheet. A Level and IGCSE papers are long; a student who is accurate but very slow will need reading practice and, possibly, an access arrangement assessment if there is a specific need.

3.3 Writing (10 minutes, 16 marks)

Say: "Turn to the Writing page. Choose one task, A or B, and tick the box. You can plan in the box, then write on the lines. You have 10 minutes. Write as much as you can." Do not explain the tasks or words.

The tasks. Task A (narrative): a story that ends with the words "and for the first time, I was glad I had stayed." Task B (argumentative): an essay for a student magazine on whether exam results are the only fair way to choose students for university, with an opinion, reasons and examples, and **at least one argument against the writer's view, answered**. The plan is not marked. Task B is the demand of an A Level entrant: an essay that recognises and answers the other side.

Score each criterion 0 to 4 (1 and 3 fall between the descriptions).

Criterion	0	2	4 (what a fluent 16 year old would do)
Content and organisation	Nothing relevant in English, or a few words copied from the task.	Relevant to the task; ideas in a sensible order but little developed; may be one block of text; the story is a sequence of events with little shape, or the essay lists reasons without explaining them and ignores the other side.	Well developed and clearly organised in paragraphs. Story: a narrator with a reason to leave, a turning point, and an ending that earns the final sentence; some control of pace and detail. Essay: a clear position, reasons developed with examples, **a counter-argument stated fairly and answered**, a conclusion; written for magazine readers.
Vocabulary	Isolated words, or only words from the prompt.	Everyday words used correctly but repeated ("very important", "good", "many people"); a few words chosen for effect; simple linking (and, but, because).	Wide and precise vocabulary chosen for effect (in the story: sensory and emotional detail; in the essay: the language of argument: claim, evidence, however, admittedly, nevertheless, on balance); a range of linking words; figurative language that works.
Grammar and sentences	No sentences.	Mostly simple sentences, some joined with and, but, because; frequent errors in verb forms, plurals and articles, but the meaning is clear.	A variety of sentence types used for effect, including complex sentences and some short sentences for impact; tenses controlled across the piece; errors are rare and do not affect meaning.
Spelling and punctuation	Mostly impossible to read.	Common words spelt correctly; capital letters and full stops mostly correct; errors in less common words.	Almost all words spelt correctly, including ambitious ones; a range of punctuation (commas after openers and in lists, speech marks in the story, apostrophes, colons and semicolons) used correctly.

Band by best fit, using the descriptors in `00_Admissions_Guide.md`, Section 6, and the notes below. The total is a check, not a rule: as a rough guide, totals of 0 to 3 usually go with A, 4 to 7 with B, 8 to 10 with C, 11 to 13 with D and 14 to 16 with E.

Band	Writing at Year 12 entry
A	Name, isolated words or copied phrases; may write in Chinese.
B	A few short sentences on the topic, with frequent errors; meaning mostly clear.
C	A short connected piece (often 70 to 130 words) with some joined sentences; errors frequent but rarely block meaning; little paragraphing; the essay gives an opinion with one or two reasons and no counter-argument.

Band	Writing at Year 12 entry
D	An organised piece (often 130 to 220 words) with paragraphs and a range of sentences; generally accurate with occasional errors; some varied vocabulary; the essay mentions the other side, even if it does not answer it well.
E	See below.

Band E writing at this age. A fluent 16 year old usually writes 200 to 300 words in 10 minutes, in paragraphs, with controlled, varied sentences, precise vocabulary chosen for its effect on the reader, and accurate spelling and punctuation. The story creates a narrator and a turning point rather than listing events; the essay argues, uses examples, states the opposing view fairly and shows why it does not change the conclusion. This is roughly the level an A Level essay-based subject starts from.

What to look for

- Typical features of English from speakers of Chinese (missing articles, plural -s, past tense -ed, third person -s) are normal at bands C and D. Do not let them alone pull a well-organised, well-developed piece below D.
- A memorised opening ("Nowadays, with the development of society") or memorised essay phrases followed by very simple writing shows exam training more than fluency: band by what the student can produce independently.
- **The counter-argument** (Task B) is the A Level skill. A student who states the other side fairly and answers it, even in imperfect English, is showing the thinking that essay subjects need; a student with fluent English who ignores the instruction is showing something else. Note it in the assessor's comment either way.
- For A Level, the gap between the writing band and the other bands matters most: essay subjects (history, economics, English, business, psychology) are assessed almost entirely through extended writing. If writing is two bands below reading, name it in the assessor's comment on the grading sheet.

3.4 Interview, speaking and sentence reading (15 minutes, 1:1)

The questions and the speaking band descriptors are in the **Interviewer guide** (`forms/Interviewer_Guide_Y11_Y12`), and the record is the **Interview sheet** (`forms/Interview_Sheet_Y11_Y12`). The sentence reading rules are in `shared/Sentence_Reading_Guide`, the student reads from `shared/Sentence_Reading_Card`, and the results go on the **Reading front sheet**. All are in English.

- **Sentence reading first** (3 to 5 minutes). Year 12 starts at **Level 9 (sentence 25)**, the top start level. Follow the start, going-back and stopping rules and the scoring in the guide. It gives total points out of 72, an indicative reading age, meaning checks and a fluency rating, which you record on the Reading front sheet. If you already know the student is new to English, start at Level 1.
- **Interview** (about 10 minutes): choose questions from each block in the Interviewer guide, including **subject choices and why**, **university plans and countries**, **independent study and managing a heavy workload**, and what the student knows about A Level. Use the easier and stretch prompts so that every student can show their best spoken English. Ask the questions at the pace in Section 2, the same for every candidate.
- **Speaking band:** give it using the descriptors in the Interviewer guide, and record it on the Interview sheet. Pronunciation features of a speaker of Chinese do not lower the band if the student is easy to understand.

4. Maths (25 minutes, 30 marks)

Say: "Turn to the Maths page. You have 25 minutes. There are three sections. In Sections A and B, you may not use a calculator. When you get to Section C, on page 17, I will give you a calculator. Write your answers in the boxes and show your working. I can read any question to you in English. Do as much as you can, and look at every page."

The example box at the start of Section A shows what the command words and symbols mean ("in the form $a + b\sqrt{5}$", surd form, $f(x)$, $gf(x)$, $f^{-1}(x)$, dy/dx with the rule for differentiating x^n, column vectors and $|\mathbf{a}|$); the example at the start of Section B shows what "Write an equation, then solve it" means. They are there so that an English phrase or an unfamiliar notation does not hide maths the student can do. The derivative rule is given on purpose: a student who has never met differentiation can still apply a rule they have just read, and that is part of what the question measures.

Section	Questions	Marks	Calculator	What it measures
A Fluency	1 to 6	10	No	Algebra at the end of IGCSE Extended and the start of A Level Maths, with no context: surds, an exponential equation by indices, composite and inverse functions, differentiating a polynomial and the gradient of a curve, column vectors and magnitude, completing the square and solving in surd form. Demanding on purpose: these students usually find routine algebra easy.
B Word questions	7 to 10	8	No	Maths given only in sentences, with no diagram: the student must read, decide what to do and, usually, form an equation. An arithmetic sequence and its sum, inverse proportion to a square, a quadratic from two numbers, and a speed-time equation leading to a quadratic.
C Applied problems	11 to 16	12	Scientific	Multi-step problems in real contexts with a diagram, a graph or a table: the cosine rule, a transformation of a graph, a cumulative frequency graph, a probability tree with conditional probabilities, a Venn diagram with set notation, and exponential growth with a decision to explain.

Calculator. Section C only. Before question 11, check that the calculator shows D or DEG (degrees). Note how fluently the student uses one (cos, powers, fractions) in the assessor's comment on the grading sheet: A Level Maths assumes it.

Marking. M = method mark, A = accuracy mark (depends on the method), B = independent mark. A correct answer with no working gets full marks unless the scheme says otherwise: in questions 9 and 10 (which ask for an equation) a correct answer with no equation scores 1, and in question 16 a tick with no figures scores 0. Units are not needed unless stated. Working in numbers and symbols is fine; any words must be in English (a reason written in Chinese scores 0, but the figures beside it still count).

What a Year 12 entrant may not have been taught. A student from a Chinese mainstream school has usually completed **Grade 10 (高一)**, so **algebra is a strength** and much of this paper is familiar: surds (Grade 8), quadratics by factorising, the formula and completing the square (Grade 9, 配方法), exponential equations by equating indices (高一, 指数函数), composite functions (高一, 复合函数), vectors in two dimensions (高一, 平面向量), the sine and cosine rules (高一, 正弦定理和余弦定理), translations of graphs (高一, 图象变换, mostly for trigonometric functions), set notation and Venn diagrams (高一, 集合), and classical probability (高一). Some content on this paper is taught later in the Chinese sequence, or not at all, so it **may not have been taught** even to a strong student: **differentiation** (导数, 高二), arithmetic sequences and their sum (数列, usually 高二, although many students meet the sum formula earlier), inverse functions written as $f^{-1}(x)$ (反函数 is touched on only briefly in 高一), **cumulative frequency graphs** and quartiles read from them (Chinese statistics uses frequency histograms and percentiles instead), conditional probability on a tree diagram (条件概率, 高二) and the English conventions of "show how you decide". A student from an IGCSE school should have met all of it. Use NT and judge whether the student would reach the expected band once taught: a strong 高一 student usually learns these quickly.

Section A: Fluency (no calculator)

Q	Topic	Answer	Marks and partial credit	May not have been taught?
1	Surds: expanding brackets	$3 - \sqrt{5}$ ($a = 3$, $b = -1$)	B1. ($5 - 2\sqrt{5} + \sqrt{5} - 2$.) An answer of $3 - 3\sqrt{5}$ or $3 + \sqrt{5}$ shows a sign slip in the middle terms; $7 - \sqrt{5}$ means $\sqrt{5} \times \sqrt{5}$ was taken as 25 or 10: note which.	Secure (Grade 8, 二次根式).
2	Exponential equation by equating indices	$x = 5/2$ (2.5)	B1. ($81 = 3^4$, so $2x - 1 = 4$.) An answer of 2 (from $2x = 4$) or 41 (from $2x - 1 = 81$) scores 0; note the second: it means indices were not understood.	Secure (高一, 指数与指数函数; index laws are Grade 8).

Q	Topic	Answer	Marks and partial credit	May not have been taught?
3	Composite and inverse functions	(a) 5 (b) $f^{-1}(x) = 2x + 3$	(a) B1: f(7) = 2, g(2) = 5. An answer of 23.5 is fg(7) (the functions in the wrong order). (b) B1. Accept $y = 2x + 3$ or equivalents. An answer of $2/(x - 3)$ scores 0: it confuses the inverse with the reciprocal.	Composite functions are 高一. The notation f^{-1} may not have been taught (反函数 is only touched on); the example box explains it, and a student who uses it correctly after reading it is showing the learning A Level needs.
4	Differentiating a polynomial; the gradient of a curve	(a) $3x^2 - 12x + 5$ (b) −7	(a) B1: all three terms correct. (b) B1 (follow through from their dy/dx if it has at least two correct terms). An answer of −6 for (b) (substituting $x = 2$ into y) scores 0 and shows that the gradient function was not understood.	**Differentiation is 高二 (导数): may not have been taught.** The example box gives the rule; a student who applies it correctly is reading mathematics in English and generalising a rule, which is exactly what A Level Maths asks for.
5	Column vectors: scalar multiple and magnitude	(a) (8, −6) as a column vector (b) $\sqrt{10}$	(a) B1. (6 + 2, −2 − 4.) An answer of (4, 2) is $2\mathbf{a} + \mathbf{b}$; (1, −5) is $\mathbf{a} - \mathbf{b}$. (b) B1 for $\sqrt{10}$ ($\mathbf{a} + \mathbf{b}$ = (1, 3), so $\sqrt{(1 + 9)}$). Accept 3.16 with $\sqrt{10}$ seen; 3.16 alone is B0 (surd form asked for). 4 (1 + 3) scores 0: the magnitude is not understood.	Secure for a 高一 student (平面向量, 必修二), who writes vectors as (3, −1) rather than in a column: accept either. A student from an IGCSE school knows column vectors.
6	Completing the square; solving in surd form	(a) $(x - 4)^2 - 13$ (b) $x = 4 + \sqrt{13}$ or $x = 4 - \sqrt{13}$	(a) B1. $(x - 4)^2 + 13$ or $(x - 4)^2 - 19$ (3 + 16) scores 0. (b) B1 for $4 \pm \sqrt{13}$, following through from a correct form; accept $(8 \pm \sqrt{52})/2$ from the formula. Decimals (7.61 and 0.39) alone score B0 (surd form asked for).	Secure (Grade 9, 配方法 and 公式法).

Section B: Word questions (no calculator)

Q	Topic	Answer	Marks and partial credit	May not have been taught?
7	Arithmetic sequence: nth term and sum	(a) Week 15 (b) ¥636	(a) B1: $6n + 14 > 100$, or listing to 104 in week 15. Week 14 (¥98, not yet more than 100) scores 0. (b) B1: 12/2 × (20 + 86) = 636, or 12 × 20 + 6 × 66, or adding the twelve terms. ¥86 (the twelfth week's amount, not the total) scores 0.	The sum of an arithmetic sequence (等差数列) is usually 高二: may not have been taught, but adding twelve numbers or pairing them (Gauss) is within reach of any strong student. The English of "first save more than" is the thing to check if (a) is wrong: read it aloud.
8	Inverse proportion to a square	40 units	M1 for $B = k/d^2$ with k = 360 (90 × 4), or $B \times 9 = 90 \times 4$; A1 for 40. 60 (inverse proportion to the distance, 90 × 2/3) scores 0: "the square" was missed. 202.5 (direct proportion to the square) scores 0.	Inverse proportion (反比例函数) is Grade 9; "inversely proportional to the square" is less familiar. If wrong, read it aloud.

Q	Topic	Answer	Marks and partial credit	May not have been taught?
9	A quadratic from two numbers (sum and sum of squares)	2 and 7	B1 for a correct equation in one unknown: $x^2 + (9 - x)^2 = 53$, or $x^2 - 9x + 14 = 0$ (or the pair $x + y = 9$, $x^2 + y^2 = 53$ reduced to one unknown); B1 for 2 and 7. Correct answer with no equation (trial): 1 mark. The equation $(9 - x)^2$ expanded as $81 - x^2$ or $81 + x^2$ scores 0 for the equation.	Secure (Grade 9, 一元二次方程的应用). If it is wrong or blank but the student solves it once it is read aloud, the barrier is English.
10	A speed-time equation leading to a quadratic	12 km/h	M1 for a correct equation: $12/v - 12/(v + 3) = 1/5$ (12 minutes as 1/5 hour; or 0.2) or equivalent ($12/v - 12/(v + 3) = 12/60$); A1 for 12. The quadratic $v^2 + 3v - 180 = 0$ factorises as $(v + 15)(v - 12)$. Using 12 (minutes) instead of 1/5 hour on the right-hand side is M0 A0 (units not converted): note it. Correct answer with no equation: 1 mark.	Secure maths: a classic 分式方程 application from Grade 8. If it is wrong, the English is the likely barrier: read it aloud.

Section C: Applied problems (scientific calculator)

Q	Topic	Answer	Marks and partial credit	May not have been taught?
11	The cosine rule in context	125 m (125.0)	M1 for $AB^2 = 120^2 + 95^2 - 2 \times 120 \times 95 \times \cos 70°$ (= 15 627); A1 for 125 (accept 125.0 or 125.01). An answer of 153 (14 400 + 9 025 + 7 798: a plus sign) is M0. 149 or 160 means the sine rule or Pythagoras was used: M0. cos 70 = 0.634 means the calculator is in radians: note it.	Secure for a 高一 student (余弦定理, 必修二). The English "3 significant figures" is the thing to check.
12	Transformations of graphs	(a) (2, 8) (b) (1, 5)	(a) B1. (b) B1. An answer of (3, 5) for (b) is the common error: f(x + 1) moves the curve 1 to the **left**. (2, 6) for (b) treats the +1 as a vertical move.	Translations of graphs are 高一 (图象的平移, mostly for $y = \sin(x + \phi)$), so the idea is familiar but the f($x + a$) notation may be new. The left-right error is common everywhere.
13	Cumulative frequency graph: median and interquartile range	(a) 60 (b) 31	(a) B1: read at cumulative frequency 40; accept 59 to 61. (b) M1 for reading at 20 and 60 (lower quartile about 44, upper quartile about 75), or 75 – 44 seen; A1 for 29 to 33. Reading the quartiles at marks 25 and 75 on the horizontal axis (giving cumulative frequencies, about 4 and 60) scores 0: the axes were confused. 100 – 0 (the range) scores 0.	**Cumulative frequency graphs and quartiles are not taught in Chinese schools** (statistics uses frequency histograms, the median from a histogram and percentiles): may not have been taught. A student from an IGCSE school knows them.
14	Probability tree with conditional probabilities	(a) 0.3 and 0.6 (b) 0.34	(a) B1 for both missing probabilities. (b) B1 for 0.34 (0.6 × 0.3 + 0.4 × 0.4 = 0.18 + 0.16); accept 17/50. 0.18 or 0.16 alone (one route) scores 0 for (b); 0.46 or 0.48 (treating the matches as independent with 0.6 or 0.7 for the second) scores 0: the conditional probabilities were not used.	Tree diagrams are Grade 9 (树状图). Conditional probability as such is 高二 (条件概率), but the tree gives the probabilities, so a 高一 student can complete it: usually within reach.
15	Venn diagram and set notation	(a) P only 16, P ∩ C 8, C only 10, outside 6; n(P ∩ C) = 8 (b) 13/20	(a) B1 for 8 in the intersection with the other three regions correct (24 + 18 – 34 = 8). 24 and 18 written inside the circles with the overlap empty (and the total 48) scores 0. (b) B1 for 26/40 = 13/20 (accept 0.65, 65%), following through from a diagram with the right structure. 8/40 (both subjects) or 34/40 (at least one) scores 0.	Sets, Venn diagrams and the notation ∩ and ∪ are the first topic of 高一 (集合): secure. The English "exactly one" is the thing to check.

Q	Topic	Answer	Marks and partial credit	May not have been taught?
16	Exponential growth with a decision (Show)	No: after 8 years the population is about 58 500, below 60 000	M1 for $48\,000 \times 1.025^8$, or the table completed correctly to year 8 (50 430, 51 691, 52 983, 54 308, 55 665, 57 057, 58 483; rounded to the nearest whole number or ten is fine); A1 for "No" with 58 483 (accept 58 400 to 58 500) seen. A tick with no figures scores 0. Adding ¥1 200 a year (simple growth: 57 600 in year 8) also reaches "No" but is M0 A0: the growth was not compounded. 48 000 × 1.2 = 57 600 (adding the percentages) is M0. The population first passes 60 000 in year 10 (61 444).	Exponential growth is 高一 (指数函数的应用) and repeated percentage change is Grade 9 (增长率): usually secure. The decision and "show how you decide" are the unfamiliar part: a correct tick with no working is common and scores 0.

Sub-scores and total: Fluency (questions 1 to 6) / 10; Word questions (7 to 10) / 8; Applied (11 to 16) / 12; total / 30.

Band guide (provisional, for a demanding paper; review after the first 20 to 30 candidates): 0 to 10 (under 35%): **1** Below expected; 11 to 16 (35 to 54%): **2** Working towards; 17 to 22 (55 to 74%): **3** Expected; 23 to 30 (75% or more): **4** Greater depth, likely top set and a candidate for Further Maths.

Not tested in version 3.1 (not enough time): inequalities, circle theorems, similarity with area and volume factors, upper and lower bounds, the sine rule, histograms, simultaneous equations with one quadratic. Ask about them in the interview if they matter for setting, and use the optional sciences for applied calculation.

Reading the three sub-scores

Profile	What it usually means	What to do
Fluency high (7 or more out of 10), **word questions low** (3 or less out of 8)	The English of the questions, not the maths, is the barrier.	Read the word questions aloud in English and, if a Chinese-speaking colleague is present, once in Chinese (mark L). If the student then solves them, record "English barrier in maths" on the grading sheet. This student needs maths vocabulary and practice in reading problems, not a lower course.
Fluency and word questions high, **applied low** (5 or less out of 12)	The student calculates and sets up equations well but is less practised in multi-step problems in context, in reading graphs and in explaining a decision. Check the NT topics first: questions 13 and 14 include content a 高一 student has not met.	Teaching in problem solving and explaining, not more content. Practice with "explain" and "show that" questions.
All three high (band 4)	A strong mathematician who can read and apply.	A Level Maths; discuss Further Maths if the school offers it.
Fluency low, word questions and applied higher	Unusual for a student from a Chinese mainstream school; more common from an international school where formal algebra comes later.	Check which algebra has been taught. A Level Maths may still fit, with an algebra catch-up plan and a review after one term.
All three low, not explained by NT or L	Gaps in earlier learning, or a possible learning need.	Look at the quantitative reasoning score on the cognitive screen, then consider further assessment before a decision (`00_Admissions_Guide.md`, Section 9).

What to look for

- **Strong responses** show organised working, correct notation and a decision backed by figures (question 16), and attempt the unfamiliar topics (questions 4, 13 and 14) by reading the example box or the diagram, even when they are new.
- **A correct tick with no reason** (question 16) is common from students used to answer-only questions. It scores 0, but it is a habit that can be taught quickly, not a gap in maths: note it in the assessor's comment on the grading sheet.
- **English or maths?** Question 10 is maths that almost every Chinese-school student knows well (a 分式方程 application). If it is wrong or blank but the student solves it once it is read aloud, the barrier is English. The same check works for questions 7 to 9.

- **Weak responses** show errors on taught topics (questions 1, 2, 5, 6, 9, 10, 11 and 15), not just on NT topics. If most of the lost marks are NT questions (3b, 4, 7, 13 and 14), write the likely band once taught in the assessor's comment on the grading sheet.

5. Science (8 minutes, 10 marks)

Say: "Turn to the Science page. You have 8 minutes. I can read any question to you in English. Do as much as you can."

What a Year 12 entrant may not have been taught. A student who has completed 高一 has done three years of junior-high biology and physics, one year of junior-high chemistry (Grade 9) and the first senior-high year of all three (physics: motion, forces, Newton's laws, energy; chemistry: the mole, redox, the periodic table, electrolytes; biology: cells and molecules). Everything on this core paper has usually been taught, with two exceptions noted below (question 5, the wave equation, is 高二 physics; the ecology terms in question 1 are Grade 8 biology and may be half-remembered). Judge scientific thinking from question 4, and judge the sciences the student will take from the optional papers.

Q	Topic	Answer	Marks and partial credit	May not have been taught?
1	Food chains: trophic levels	Frog	B1. "Grasshopper" (the primary consumer) or "snake" (the tertiary consumer) scores 0; note which, because both show the chain was understood but not the term.	Food chains are Grade 8 biology (生态系统); the term "secondary consumer" in English is the thing to check.
2	Series circuits: resistance and current	(a) 12 Ω (b) 0.5 A	(a) B1. 2.67 Ω (resistors treated as parallel) scores 0. (b) B1 for 0.5 (6 ÷ 12), following through from their total (6 ÷ 2.67 = 2.25 A scores B1 only if (a) was 2.67). 1.5 A (6 ÷ 4) or 0.75 A (6 ÷ 8) scores 0.	Secure (Grade 9 physics, 串联电路 and 欧姆定律).
3	The mole: moles from mass	0.25 mol	B1. (M_r = 24 + 16 = 40; 10.0 ÷ 40.) An answer of 0.42 (10 ÷ 24, the oxygen forgotten) or 400 (10 × 40) scores 0.	Secure (高一 chemistry, 物质的量).
4	Working scientifically: pattern, variables, evaluating a method	(a) Height increases with fertiliser up to 2 g per litre, then decreases (b) One control variable (c) One sensible improvement	(a) B1: both parts of the pattern needed (the rise and the fall); "more fertiliser, taller plant" alone scores 0 because it ignores 3 and 4 g per litre. (b) B1: the same type (species) of plant, the same size of plant at the start, the same amount (volume) of water, the same soil, the same pot, the same light, the same temperature, the same time (4 weeks). Do not accept "the fertiliser" or "the height". (c) B1: grow several plants at each concentration and find the mean height; repeat the experiment; measure the mass (dry mass) as well as height; use more concentrations between 1 and 3. Do not accept "do it more carefully".	Fertiliser and plant growth are Grade 7 biology. Evaluating a method is less familiar: score what the student writes.
5	The wave equation	20 m/s	B1. (50 × 0.4.) 125 (50 ÷ 0.4) or 0.008 scores 0.	$v = f\lambda$ is 高二 physics (机械波): may not have been taught, but the equation is given on the paper, so a student can read the wavelength (0.4 m) from the diagram and multiply.

Q	Topic	Answer	Marks and partial credit	May not have been taught?
6	Ionic compounds: conduction when molten	Ions can move when molten (free to move, carry the charge); in the solid, the ions are held in fixed positions (in a lattice) and cannot move	B1 for the idea that the **ions** move when molten and not when solid. "Electrons move" scores 0 (this is the common confusion with metals). "Because it melts" scores 0.	Secure (高一 chemistry, 电解质 and 离子键; Grade 9 introduces ions).
7	Gas exchange: adaptations of the alveolus	One feature with its reason: a wall one cell thick (a short distance for diffusion); a capillary right next to it or a good blood supply (keeps the concentration gradient steep, carries gases away quickly); a large surface area from many alveoli (more diffusion at once); a moist surface (gases dissolve)	B1 for a feature **and** why it helps. A feature alone ("thin wall") scores 0 at this level; "it has air in it" scores 0.	Secure (Grade 7 biology, 呼吸系统; 高一 biology covers diffusion across membranes). The English of "feature" and "gas exchange" is the thing to check.

Band guide (provisional): 0 to 3: **1**; 4 to 5: **2**; 6 to 8: **3**; 9 to 10: **4**. Look at the NT questions before deciding. For the sciences the student will take at A Level, the optional papers (15 marks each) are the better evidence: see Section 6.

Not tested on the core paper (not enough time): genetics, homeostasis, enzymes, rates of reaction, electrolysis, organic chemistry, magnetism, radioactivity, momentum. The optional sciences cover them.

What to look for

- **Working scientifically** (question 4) is the best guide to A Level practical work: a student who sees the rise and the fall in the data, names a control variable and suggests a real improvement is ready for practical work in English.
- **An English barrier** looks like: blank or wrong answers that become right when you read the question aloud. Science vocabulary in English (secondary consumer, resistance, moles, variable, molten, feature) is often the gap: note the words the student did not know in the assessor's comment on the grading sheet.
- **Strong responses** use units (Ω, A, mol, m/s), give both halves of an explanation (question 7) and give precise answers in question 4 (for example "grow five plants at each concentration and calculate the mean").

6. Readiness for A Level

This section is guidance for the school to confirm, against its own admissions policy, the A Level subjects and syllabuses it offers, the entry requirements it sets for each subject, the university destinations its students aim for, and the support it can provide. It is not a set of fixed rules. Record the results on the grading sheet (Section 7) first, then read the results together.

English is the gateway. Every A Level subject is taught and examined in English, with long texts, extended written answers and essay questions. The demand is higher than at IGCSE, and there is less time: a two-year A Level course leaves little room for English to catch up. Look at the overall English band, and most closely at **reading and writing**, because the exams depend on them. Academic English usually develops more slowly than conversation: as a planning assumption, a student rarely moves up more than about one band a year in academic reading and writing, even with good support. A student at band C at the start of Year 12 is likely still to be at C or D when the exams come.

English band	What it usually means for A Level study in English	English course that may fit best
A New to English	Cannot yet follow subject lessons in English. Direct entry to A Level is not usually advisable (`00_Admissions_Guide.md`, Section 9).	A preparatory or foundation route, or a later start, if the school has one.
B Early acquisition	Can follow simple, supported lessons, but A Level texts and exam questions will be out of reach for most of the first year.	Direct entry to A Level is not usually advisable; a one-year pre-A Level or IGCSE year with intensive English, if the school has one.

English band	What it usually means for A Level study in English	English course that may fit best
C Developing competence	Can follow most lessons with support; subject vocabulary and extended writing will slow progress. Maths and the sciences are more accessible than essay-based subjects.	**English as a Second Language support** alongside A Levels in maths and the sciences only; essay-based subjects not advised in the first year, or a pre-A Level year.
D Competent	Usually ready for A Level courses taught in English, with support for academic writing; essay-based subjects possible with support.	English as a Second Language support at the higher level in the first year; First Language level if reading and writing are a strong D or E.
E Fluent	Ready for A Level study in English, including essay-based subjects.	**First Language level** (no ESL course needed); English Literature or Language at A Level if the student wants it.

What English band does a student realistically need? As a working guide for the school to test and review: **band D or above in reading and writing** for essay-based subjects (for example economics, business, history, psychology, English), and **band C or above in reading and writing, with English as a Second Language support**, for maths and the sciences. Listening and speaking at C or above in either case. Review these thresholds once the first groups of students have taken their A Levels.

What the version 3.1 English results add. Use the hardest parts as the evidence for A Level:

- **Listening Part B** is the best guide to following lessons taught by talk. Part B 6 or more: the student can follow a lesson-style explanation with subject vocabulary and hear its argument. Part B 0 to 2 with Part A secure: everyday listening is fine, but lessons will need visual support and key vocabulary in writing at first.
- **Reading Part B** ("Lost, and Better for It") is a First Language-style opinion article and the hardest reading on this paper. Part B 7 or 8, answered in the student's own words, with writing at E or a strong D: reads like a fluent speaker and is ready for essay-based subjects. Part B 6 or more otherwise: a competent reader who will need support with the longest A Level texts.
- **Writing Task B** (the essay with a counter-argument) is the closest task on this paper to an A Level essay. A clear position, a fairly stated counter-argument and an answer to it, in organised paragraphs, is the mark of readiness for essay subjects even when the English has band D errors.

Maths: A Level Maths, and what support. Read the total band with the three sub-scores (Section 4), allowing for NT. A Level Maths assumes the whole of IGCSE Extended (or its equivalent) and fluent algebra.

Maths result	What it suggests (for the school to confirm)
Band 4 (23 or more)	**A Level Maths: suitable**, likely top set. Discuss **Further Maths** if the school offers it, especially if questions 4, 5 and 16 are right.
Band 3 (17 to 22)	**A Level Maths: suitable.** NT marks on differentiation, inverse functions, sequences and cumulative frequency are expected for a 高一 student and are usually caught up in the first term.
Fluency 7 or more, word questions 3 or less (any band)	**A Level Maths with support for the English of maths**: maths vocabulary, reading problems, writing short explanations in English. The gap is English, not maths: do not advise against A Level Maths for this reason alone.
Fluency and word questions secure, applied 5 or less	**A Level Maths with support** in problem solving, reading graphs and explaining ("show that", "explain"). Review after one term.
Band 2 (11 to 16), mostly NT and L	**A Level Maths is still possible**: judge the band once taught, and review after six weeks.
Band 2 with errors on taught topics (questions 1, 2, 5, 6, 9, 10, 11, 15)	**A Level Maths not advised** without a catch-up plan; a pre-A Level year, or A Level subjects that do not depend on maths, may be wiser. Review if the gaps close.
Band 1 not explained by NT or English	Further assessment before a decision (`00_Admissions_Guide.md`, Section 9). A band 1 that NT or L does explain is treated as band 2 (the guide, Section 9).

The optional sciences and A Level sciences. Each optional paper (15 marks, band 1 to 4 from `Y12_Optional_Sciences_Mark_Scheme_v3.1`) is the main evidence for that A Level science. As a working guide:

band 3 or 4 in a science suggests **suitable** for that A Level; band 2 suggests **with support** (a content catch-up plan for the NT topics named in the mark scheme, and a review after one term); band 1 not explained by NT suggests **not advised** for that science. Read each science with the maths result (physics and chemistry at A Level depend on algebra) and with the English band (every science has extended-answer questions). A science the student did not sit cannot be judged: tick "not taken" and do not infer it from the others.

The cognitive ability screen and support planning. The screen is **not used to select**. Use its profile (`shared/Cognitive_Ability_Screen_Guide`) to plan support: non-verbal and quantitative both 9 or more with verbal low usually means strong reasoning and an English gap (plan language support, and expect the paper results to rise as English does); processing speed well below the other parts suggests checking reading fluency and considering extra time; all three reasoning parts 4 or less suggests discussing further assessment before a decision (`00_Admissions_Guide.md`, Section 9); a strong profile with weak paper results suggests looking for gaps in prior learning or motivation. Write the profile note on the grading sheet.

When a one-year pre-A Level or IGCSE route is wiser. Consider it, if the school offers one, when: English is band B, or band C with essay-based subjects wanted; the student has not sat IGCSE and the maths is band 2 on taught topics; the optional sciences for the subjects wanted are band 1 or 2 with many NT topics; or the interview shows that the student does not yet understand what A Level study in English involves. A year of IGCSE in English usually raises the English band, fills the content gaps and produces the IGCSE grades that universities and the school's own entry requirements may ask for. Tell the family early what the school's requirements are.

Reading the results together (examples of common profiles)

Profile	What it suggests	A possible plan (for the school to confirm)
English D or E; maths 3 or 4; optional sciences 3 or 4 in the subjects wanted	Ready for a full A Level programme.	Full subject load; English course by the table above; A Level Maths.
English E, with listening Part B high, reading Part B 7 or 8 in own words, and writing E or a strong D with a counter-argument	Reads and writes like a fluent speaker.	First Language level; essay-based subjects open; no ESL course needed.
English C; maths fluency high, word questions well below it; sciences 3 or 4	Strong maths and science; English is the barrier.	A Level Maths and the sciences with ESL support; no essay-based subject in the first year; review English after one term.
English C or D; maths fluency and word questions high, applied low; cognitive screen quantitative high	Strong calculation and algebra; less practised in problem solving and explaining.	A Level Maths with explicit teaching of problem solving and "explain" questions; review after one term.
English C; maths 2 with NT on differentiation, sequences and cumulative frequency; sciences 2 with NT topics	Likely to manage with support, or better placed in a pre-A Level year.	If entry: ESL support, catch-up plans for the NT topics, maths and sciences reviewed after six weeks. Otherwise a pre-A Level or IGCSE year.
English B, any maths and sciences	The English gap is too wide for A Level content in two years.	A pre-A Level or IGCSE year with intensive English, if the school has one; otherwise discuss a later start (`00_Admissions_Guide.md`, Section 9).
English D or E; maths band 1 on taught topics; cognitive screen quantitative low	Not an English issue.	Further assessment before a decision (`00_Admissions_Guide.md`, Section 9). If an offer follows, no A Level Maths, and maths support where other subjects need it.
Cognitive screen strong (non-verbal and quantitative 9 or more), verbal and all paper results low	Strong reasoning; the English is the whole gap.	A pre-A Level year with intensive English is likely to pay off; review the paper results after the year.
Strong results, but the interview shows the A Level plan (subjects, country, university) is the family's, not the student's	Readiness is not only academic.	Talk with the family and student about subject choices and workload before an offer (Interview sheet, suitability strands). A serious mismatch, or any strand rated 1, goes to the head of section before any offer.

Use the Year 11 and 12 interview questions (subject choices and why, university plans, independent study, managing a heavy workload, what the student knows about A Level) to judge whether the student's plans are realistic and their own. Record the readiness judgement on the grading sheet (the readiness for A Level boxes and the assessor's comment) and on the final mark sheet (`forms/Candidate_Summary_and_Decision`).

7. Recording the results

1. **Mark the student paper.** Every question has a mark box.
2. **Copy the totals onto the grading sheet** (`Y12_Grading_Sheet_v3.1`) and give the bands from the band guides above (the grading sheet repeats them at a glance). Record there too whether Part B of the listening was given, the maths sub-scores and profile (Section 4), the NT topics and L questions, the writing task chosen (A or B) and whether the essay answered a counter-argument, any access arrangements and your comment.
3. **Mark the optional sciences** with `Y12_Optional_Sciences_Mark_Scheme_v3.1` and record each science taken on the grading sheet (score / 15, band, NT, L); tick "not taken" for each science the student did not sit.
4. **Score the cognitive ability screen** with `shared/Cognitive_Ability_Screen_Guide` and record the four raw scores (Non-verbal / 12, Quantitative / 12, Verbal / 12, Processing speed / 60) and a one-line profile note on the grading sheet. It is not banded and it is not used to select.
5. **Record the reading results and band on the Reading front sheet** (`forms/Reading_Front_Sheet`): the reading paper marks (Part A, Part B), the band and the question where the student stopped at 15 minutes.
6. **Give the interviewer the Reading front sheet and the Interview sheet** before the interview.
7. **After the interview, put together** the grading sheet, Reading front sheet, Interview sheet and parent conversation record, and complete the final mark sheet (`forms/Candidate_Summary_and_Decision`) within two working days (or within two working days of the second visit, if there is one). Write "v3.1" beside the scores on it: the listening is out of 16, the reading paper is out of 16, the maths has three sub-scores, each optional science is out of 15 and the cognitive screen is four raw scores. The overall English band is the band most skills sit in: name any skill that is two or more bands lower.
8. **File the marked papers with them** (or shred them under the school's policy).

Year 12 only: readiness for A Level. Read the results together with Section 6, then tick on the grading sheet the English course (English as a Second Language support, First Language level or to decide), A Level Maths (suitable, with support, not advised or to decide), the sciences (suitable for the A Level sciences taken, with support, or not advised), the readiness (Ready, Ready with support, Pre-A Level year advised or Not yet) and the support (English of maths, academic writing, content gaps, extra time to check, or none), and give your reasons in the assessor's comment.